

Week 53 Deep Research -- Micro-Cap Portfolio (FINAL WEEK)

Date: Monday, 2026-09-14 (pre-market) | Week: 53 -- final | Runway: ends 2026-09-18 -- 5 sessions remain, including today

Session d
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1. RESTATED RULES

- US-listed common stock, market cap $\leq$ \$5B. No ETFs, CEFs/BDCs, SPACs, ADRs, units/warrants.
- Cash floor 8% · risk-per-trade $\leq$ 5% · max loss per new position $\leq$ 2% of equity (else reduce size) · single-name ceiling 30% · sector cap 2 (healthcare 3).
- Market regime filter: IWM below its 50-day SMA restricts new initiations to high-conviction, catalyst-driven plays.
- Stops mandatory. Anti-ratchet: no raise under 0.5xATR, must leave $\geq$ 1.5xATR. Mechanical restoration: once per position -- ATRC, PAR used theirs; VTS and any new position have not.
- PRV gate before any buy/sell. Thesis-input freshness: time-varying drivers verified within 10 trading days, current level and direction. Four-category check for unexplained moves. PT dispersion pulled for any position of consequence.

2. RESEARCH SCOPE

Retrieved 2026-09-14, 07:03-07:55 AM EDT, pre-market. Holdings priced at settled Friday 9/11 closes; pre-market prints at this hour carried no usable volume and were not relied upon.

Check	Method	Result
Data currency	--check-data-current	Passes -- last completed session 9/11
Screener	screener.py	15 candidates; weakest momentum of the final stretch
Candidate technicals + earnings dates	yfinance	No earnings inside the window for any candidate
PRV quote pages	Browser	CXW, BRBS, NMAX, LFST, BZH
CXW analyst dispersion	Browser -> forecast page	All 5 analysts Buy; range \$40-\$45
CXW / GEO news	Browser -> StockTitan, quote pages	Latest releases Aug 5-10
Detention-policy driver	WebSearch (discovery) -> browser (dating)	Negative items dated Feb 2026
Selloff dating	yfinance 12-month daily returns	Feb 12-20, 2026
VTS dividend	yfinance + S&P Global table	Ex-date Sep 15 confirmed

Three corrections made during this session

VTS ex-dividend date is Tuesday Sept 15. yfinance's calendar field showed Sept 14 and I briefly reported that as a correction; the S&P Global dividend table (ex-date Sep 15, record date Sep 15, pay date Sep 30, \$0.4375) is authoritative. The original date stands. The payment lands after the experiment ends, so the ledger will book the price drop and never the cash (~\$2.63).

CXW's fo
year -- a n

3. CURRENT PORTFOLIO ASSESSMENT

Equity \$733.51 · S&P-equivalent \$768.52 · Gap ?4.56% · Cash \$259.33 (35.4%) · TWR alpha +0.55%

Regime: F

Ticker	Role	Avg Cost	Close 9/11	P&L	Stop	Conviction	Status
ATRC	Core winner	\$34.30	\$54.54	+59.0%	\$50.30	5/5	KEEP -- partial pending
PAR	Growth	\$19.05	\$18.00	?5.5%	\$17.05	3/5	KEEP
VTS	Ballast	\$17.85	\$18.76	+5.1%	\$17.50	4/5	KEEP

ATRC closed \$0.34 below its +60% partial trigger (\$54.88) after crossing it intraday at \$55.16. All four deferral criteria technically hold. Per this session's directive, 1 share is sold if ATRC closes at or above \$54.88 -- consensus PT \$51.67 sits below the price, the BoxX-NoAF catalyst is H1 2027, and five sessions favour banking a third. Stop \$50.30 locks +46.6%; its next raise fails the anti-ratchet (0.29xATR).

PAR recovered to \$18.00 and 1.06xATR from its stop after testing it all week. Its restoration is spent. Analyst targets range \$16-\$30 with UBS and RBC at \$16 -- the lowest conviction in the book, reduced to 3/5.

VTS is doing its job as ballast on a verified oil driver (WTI >\$100). Stop \$17.50 was sized to survive tomorrow's ex-dividend with ~1.7xATR intact.

4. CANDIDATE SET

Screen quality: 20-day momentum mostly ?2.5% to +10.8%; six of fifteen closed below their 20-day SMA and fail the relative-strength entry rule outright (DBRG, CBZ, WKC, VREX, RAMP, KRP). No candidate reports earnings inside the window -- no binary events anywhere on the list.

Ticker	Sector	Revenue	Rating / PT	Verdict
CXW	Industrials	+24.3%	Strong Buy, \$41.80 (+19.7%)	[OK] BUY
BRBS	Financials	?13.2%	no coverage	[X] shrinking revenue
NMAX	Comm. Services	+11.1%	Buy, \$18.50	[X] lossmaking, fwd PE 111, ATR 4.97%, no beta history
LFST	Healthcare	+20.4%	Buy, \$14.20 (+9.5%)	[X] thin upside, at 52-wk high, \$4.96B at the cap
BZH	Cons. Disc.	?12.8%	Hold, \$27.50 (?17%)	[X] deal-pinned
UTZ, DV	--	--	--	[X] same deal-pin signature (ATR ~0.3%)
SPSC	Technology	--	--	[X] 5-day momentum ?1.8%
NATL	Technology	--	--	[X] 20-day momentum ?0.8%

On the deal-pin finding. BZH is a beta-2.18 homebuilder that closed 0.00% in an 8-cent daily range (\$33.25-\$33.33) while trading 17% above its analyst target -- the signature of a stock pinned to an acquisition price. UTZ and DV share its ~0.3% ATR with near-zero momentum. A pinned stock cannot generate return in five sessions regardless of the deal's merits.

Selected: CXW -- CoreCivic | Conviction 4/5

PRV (9/11 close): \$34.93, market cap \$3.45B, 52-week range \$15.74-35.30 (new high \$35.05 on Sept 8). Revenue TTM \$2.48B, +24.3%; net income \$127.9M; EPS \$1.25 +31.8%. Beta 0.60. ATR 3.37%. ADV \$57.8M. Next earnings Nov 4 -- outside the window.

Analyst dispersion -- the best case the rule can return. Five analysts, every one Buy or Strong Buy, unchanged April through September. Targets \$40 low, \$41.80 average, \$42 median, \$45 high -- the lowest is +14.5% above the price. Post-Q2 raises: JonesTrading \$30->\$42, Northland \$32->\$40, Benchmark \$41->\$45. StoneX maintained \$45 on Sept 11.

The catalyst that satisfies the RISK-OFF filter. On Aug 10 CoreCivic entered a \$500M accelerated share repurchase -- about 14.5% of its market cap -- under an expanded \$755.8M program, with ~12.4M shares delivered initially and final settlement before the end of Q2 2027. This is active, ongoing buying through our window, the same standard applied to VTS's verified oil driver when it was bought under RISK-OFF in Week 52. Q2 revenue rose +27.3% and guidance was revised with per-share metrics raised.

Entry-discipline checks: +3.9% over the 20-day SMA (<=20% [OK]) · +8.4% over the 50-day (<=40% [OK]) · 5-day move +3.8%, not days 1-3 of a >10% breakout [OK] · no earnings in window [OK].

Thesis-input freshness -- the driver verified, not reversing. CXW's demand rests on federal immigration detention, a policy-driven input.

Evidence	Date	Direction
ICE \$45B multi-year detention appropriation	Jul 2025	Supportive
GEO/CXW selloff on ICE insourcing report	Feb 12-20, 2026	Negative -- priced and recovered
ICE warehouse purchases (AIC)	Feb 24, 2026	Negative -- structural
FY26 appropriations: ~5,500 beds, ICE funding maintained (source)	Early 2026	Mildly negative
GEO: two new 5-year ICE contracts (~\$165M/yr) + Rivers facility (~\$80M/yr)	Jul 29 - Aug 6	Supportive
GEO and CXW both set new 52-week highs	Aug 26 / Sep 8	Supportive
ICE building its own 100 beds at Batavia (source)	Sep 2	Negative but immaterial in scale
StoneX maintains \$45 on CXW	Sep 11	Supportive

Weekly closes over five weeks: CXW rising (0 down-weeks, +6.4%); GEO down three consecutive weeks (?1.3%, ?1.6%, ?0.9%, about ?3.8%) from its Aug 26 high with no company news; XLI down four weeks (?7.6%). GEO's three-week run touches the LXU threshold numerically, but it is a shallow pullback from a fresh high amid broad Industrials weakness under a RISK-OFF regime. LXU's disqualifier was the driver itself falling five straight weeks; here the newest dated driver evidence is new contracts and new highs.

Bear case, stated plainly:

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5. PORTFOLIO ACTIONS

Keep: ATRC (5/5), VTS (4/5), PAR (3/5).

Trim: ATR

6. EXACT ORDERS

Order 1 -- BUY CXW

- Action: BUY
- Ticker: CXW -- CoreCivic (NYSE)
- Shares: 5
- Order Type: LIMIT
- Limit Price: \$34.93
- Time in Force: DAY
- Intended Execution: 2026-09-14
- Stop Loss: \$32.85 -- 1.77xATR below entry; the wider of 1.75xATR and the most recent swing low (\$33.73); below the 5-day low of \$33.15
- Stop Limit: \$32.70
- Special Instructions: The limit equals the last verified price -- the \$34.93 close, Sept 11, 4:00 PM EDT. The 4:00 AM "pre-market \$35.45" mirrored Friday's change with no volume and was not used. Re-verify a live pre-market quote with volume around 9:25 AM. Do not chase above \$35.50 (above the \$35.30 52-week high). Skip if it opens below \$33.15 (5-day low), which would break the setup.
- Rationale: The only candidate clearing every filter -- revenue +24.3%, all five analysts Buy with the lowest target +14.5% above market, an active \$500M buyback worth 14.5% of market cap, beta 0.60, no earnings in the window, driver verified not reversing.

Order 2 -- CONDITIONAL: SELL 1 ATRC

- Action: SELL (partial profit, +60% tier)
- Ticker: ATRC · Shares: 1 of 3
- Trigger: only if ATRC closes at or above \$54.88
- Execution: at the next session -- cancel the existing stop, place a DAY limit sell for 1 share at or above the prior close, then re-place the stop on the remaining 2 shares at \$50.30 / \$50.15
- Rationale: consensus PT \$51.67 is below the price and the BoxX-NoAF catalyst is H1 2027 -- banking a third of the book's best position is worth more than the remaining upside over five sessions. Scale: +\$4.24 if ATRC then stops out, ?\$5.46 if it runs to \$60.

7. RISK AND LIQUIDITY CHECKS

Post-trade allocation (CXW 5 x \$34.93 = \$174.65):

Holding	Value	% Equity
PAR	\$198.00	27.0%
CXW (new)	\$174.65	23.8%
ATRC	\$163.62	22.3%
VTS	\$112.56	15.3%
Cash	\$84.68	11.5%
TOTAL	\$733.51	100%

All under 30% [OK] · Cash above the 8% floor (\$58.68) [OK] · Sectors: Technology 1, Healthcare 1, Energy 1, Industrials 1 [OK]

Risk if stopped:

Holding	Shares	Price ? Stop	Max loss	% Equity
ATRC	3	\$54.54 ? \$50.30	\$12.72	1.73%
PAR	11	\$18.00 ? \$17.05	\$10.45	1.42%
VTS	6	\$18.76 ? \$17.50	\$7.56	1.03%
CXW	5	\$34.93 ? \$32.85	\$10.40	1.42%
Aggregate			\$41.13	5.61%

CXW gap tail (not captured by the stop): a repeat of February's ?10.3% day costs ~\$18.00 (2.45% of equity).

Liquidity: a

8. MONITORING PLAN

Holding	Watch	Trigger
ATRC	Close vs \$54.88	Close >= \$54.88 -> sell 1 share next session; stop stays \$50.30 on the rest
CXW	ICE facility / insourcing headlines; the DRI's Sept 30 deadline	A ?5% session with an ICE headline is a thesis event -- reassess same day, don't
PAR	1.06xATR from stop; restoration spent	Stop \$17.05
VTS	Ex-dividend Tuesday Sept 15 (~\$0.44 drop, no ledger credit); oil above \$100	Do not misread the ex-div drop; a sharp oil reversal is the real risk
Book	RISK-OFF regime; XLI's four-week slide	--

Calendar: VTS ex-dividend Sep 15. ICE DRI deadline Sep 30 (after the finish). No earnings for any holding or candidate before Sept 18.

9. THESIS REVIEW SUMMARY

(Reproduced as Week 53 Summary.md)

10. CONFIRM CASH AND CONSTRAINTS

Cash: \$259.33 -> \$84.68 after CXW -- 11.5% of equity, above the 8% floor.

Constraint	Status
Cash floor >=8%	[OK] 11.5%
Single-name <=30%	[OK] largest PAR 27.0%
New-position max loss <=2%	[OK] CXW 1.42%
Risk-per-trade <=5%	[OK]
Sector cap	[OK] one name per sector
Market cap <=\$5B	[OK] CXW \$3.45B

Regime filter (RISK-OFF)	[OK] catalyst-driven: active \$500M ASR
Relative strength	[OK] CXW above its 20-day SMA
Distance from base	[OK] +3.9% / +8.4%
Earnings in window	[OK] none
PRV gate	[OK]
PT dispersion	[OK] all Buy, lowest target +14.5%
Thesis-input freshness	[OK] negative items dated Feb 2026 and priced; newest evidence supportive

All constraints satisfied. One order plus one conditional order.

Week 53 Full Report -- final week. Generated 2026-09-14 by Claude Code. Posture: Aggressive · Wide net · 5-session window · add 0-1. Prices are 9/11 settled closes; ATR and range figures from settled bars through 9/11. Policy sources were found by WebSearch and dated by opening each in the browser.